

Chapter 82-5

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When Liang Shi drove to the entrance of Rainbow's kindergarten, it was right at dismissal time. Cars could no longer get in, so she could only park a bit farther away.

She got out of the car and walked toward the kindergarten entrance. Standing among the group of moms, she felt out of place.

Though the other moms probably didn't feel that way.

She also saw Sun Meirou at the school entrance, there to pick up Ling Dang.

The two stood there chatting for a while. Sun Meirou looked worried, so Liang Shi comforted her with a few words.

Sun Meirou smiled helplessly: "Why are you comforting me? You're the one having the hardest time right now. Where are you living now? If you don't have a place, Xinhe bought one before—you can move in there first."

Liang Xinhe wasn't as wealthy as Liang Xinzhou, who had bought three to five properties outside.

Liang Xinhe had a child to raise at home, didn't have much authority in the company, and spent money extravagantly. He used to give Liang Shi hundreds of thousands in pocket money and basically hadn't saved any money at all.

He had only bought one property, probably kept for emergencies.

After all, Liang Xinhe probably never thought he would move out of the old residence.

Liang Shi declined: "Second sister-in-law, no need. I have a place to stay."

"Do you still have money?" Sun Meirou asked. "I have some here too. Don't think it's too little."

As she spoke, she handed over a bank card. "It's what I saved before. It can help you in an emergency."

"I'm really not in need." Liang Shi said helplessly, pushing the card back to her. "Keep it to buy things for Ling Dang. I have money on hand."

Sun Meirou looked troubled and could only sigh helplessly.

But Liang Shi said to her: "Ling Dang is a child. She's always been the only one at home, so she's used to speaking without a filter. Plus, she's at the age where she likes to imitate what people say. Be more careful at home. About what happened last night....."

Sun Meirou frowned, also looking quite troubled.

"You still need to protect the child's innocence." Liang Shi said. "It's hard on you, second sister-in-law."

"I know." Sun Meirou said. "I don't have any objections to that new little sister, but what Ling Dang said last night—she's probably holding a grudge now. Mother-in-law listens to everything she says now, afraid we might make her feel wronged. To be honest with you, I've been walking on eggshells all day."

Liang Shi lowered her eyes and suggested quietly: "Have you thought about moving out?"

"I brought it up last night—let's just move out like big brother did." Sun Meirou said. "But your second brother said that big brother moving out already made Mom so angry she got sick. If we move out too....."

Sun Meirou shook her head helplessly. "Forget it. I'll just endure it. As long as I protect Ling Dang, it'll be fine. No matter how bad she is, she wouldn't go after a child."

Liang Shi respected her decision and only reminded her to make sure Ling Dang doesn't run wild like before.

When Ling Dang came out, she circled around Liang Shi, pitifully complaining that she didn't like the new auntie and wanted to go home with Liang Shi that night.

But Liang Shi persuaded her to go back. It was already a sensitive period—the Liang Xinzhou couple had just moved out. If Ling Dang didn't go home at night either, it would probably trigger another round of arguments.

Although Liang Shi also kind of wanted to anger Qiu Zimin, using a child wasn't right.

Ling Dang dejectedly followed Sun Meirou away.

By the time she picked up Rainbow, it was getting late. Dusk was falling, and the streetlights around them lit up all at once, casting the autumn scenery in a dim, beautiful glow.

Liang Shi held Rainbow's hand and walked toward the car. When they were almost there, she saw Qi Jiao walking out. After a moment's thought, she handed the car keys to Rainbow, telling her to go wait in the car while she took care of something.

Rainbow first pressed the unlock button to confirm which car it was, then looked up and asked her: "Are you going to find Teacher Qi again?"

Liang Shi nodded.

Rainbow tugged at her backpack straps as she walked, not forgetting to say: "You look for Teacher Qi every time you come. Won't Sister Xu really get angry?"

Liang Shi was startled: "Why would she get angry?"

Rainbow stopped in her tracks and looked at her with an expression of disappointment¹: "Teacher Qi is also a pretty girl, you know."

Liang Shi: "....."

Rainbow said earnestly: "Jiejie Liang, doing this will make Sister Xu jealous."

Liang Shi: "....."

She said helplessly: "Don't worry about adults' relationship problems."

Rainbow pouted and went to wait in the car.

Liang Shi quickly walked over to find Qi Jiao. Qi Jiao also caught sight of her from the corner of her eye and walked even faster, but Liang Shi still caught up to her.

"Teacher Qi." Liang Shi stood with her by the roadside. "Why are you running?"

Qi Jiao clutched the strap of her canvas bag and asked in return: "Why are you chasing?"

Liang Shi: "I want to ask you about something."

Qi Jiao pressed her lips together: "I have nothing to say."

She was dressed the same as before—a light yellow long dress with a cardigan over it, her hair in a half ponytail with the rest draped softly over her shoulders, and a light purple hair tie on her head.

She looked gentle and serene.

Liang Shi suddenly thought of that little girl nestled beside Gu Zhaoyuan.

After seeing her teenage photos and then looking at her now, she seemed to have been prettier before.

Now there were traces of artificiality, though you couldn't tell at all unless you looked closely.

Footnotes:

¹ **"Looked at her with an expression of disappointment"** (恨鐵不成鋼): A Chinese idiom that literally means "hating iron for not becoming steel." It describes the feeling of frustration or disappointment when someone you care about fails to meet expectations or doesn't live up to their potential. Here, Rainbow is using this expression humorously, acting like a disappointed elder toward Liang Shi's romantic obliviousness.